

A critique of COVID-19 lockdown measures in African countries: The price of universal copying and mass pasting.*

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Abstract

In the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic blockbuster, Africa remains at the spotlight of a twist between speculations around the vulnerability of the continent and the shocking eventuality of the outcomes. Though Africa recorded the least spread of the pandemic, the approach taken by the different countries in containing COVID-19 has raised several debates considering their economic institutions, health infrastructure and poverty incidence. Hence, drawing on the available strands of literature, this article seeks to critique the lockdown measures in African countries to see whether they are an unavoidable step or a misguided decision. Along this parallel, this paper will investigate the COVID-19 pandemic and the globalisation discourse, COVID-19 in Africa- low spread and strict lockdown, the price for universal copying and mass

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pasting and finally, it will examine the impact of lockdown in the continent.

Keywords: COVID-19 pandemic, coronavirus, Africa, lockdown

1 Introduction

The world has rarely experienced a global standstill until the unprecedented COVID-19 pandemic hit, that, even the most sophisticated systems were caught unaware. Reported to have emerged from Wuhan city in China, the virus responsible for this global conundrum spread rapidly like wildfire (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). Within a month of declaring COVID-19 a global pandemic, specifically in April 2020, the World Health Organisation already reported over 2.1million confirmed cases in 213 countries with 142,229 mortality (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). Significantly, this figure spiralled to 4 million cases and almost twice the mortality rate, about 318,789 deaths a month after COVID-19 was declared a pandemic (Balde *et al.*, 2020). Already, virtually all countries are now affected, the figure, according to WHO, now stands at 198,778, 175 confirmed cases globally with 4,235,559 confirmed deaths recorded as of 3rd August 2021 (WHO, 2021a).

Moreover, at the wake of this pandemic, Africa as a continent attracted global empathy with speculations around the frail state of its socio-economic infrastructure and the preparedness of the continent in containing the virus. On the contrary, Africa was the last continent to be hit by the pandemic. Specifically, on the 14th of February 2020, Africa confirmed its first case in Egypt while the Sub-Saharan region recorded its first in Nigeria on the 27th of the same month (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). With a relatively low rate of infection, from that February to mid-September, significantly, less than 5 percent of the global COVID-19 confirmed cases were in the second most populous continent (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020). Shocked by this development, arguments began to spring up from different corners

regarding the containment strategies that several countries in Africa aggressively adopted in mitigating the impact of the pandemic and its short and long-term implications.

Globally, the response to the virulent spread of COVID-19 was restrictions and lockdown measures involving the suspension of international flights, land and sea border closure with certain exemptions for food, goods and commodities (Haider *et al.*, 2020). Other precautionary measures include mandatory quarantine and use of facemasks, social distancing, etc.(Lakemann *et al.*, 2020). While the concept of lockdown remained ubiquitous as Haider *et al.*, (2020) contended, no absolute definition of the scope and scale was stipulated, and so many African countries were swift to rigidly depend on it as a containment strategy– commonly switching between the presumptive partial and total lockdown (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020).

Unlike other countries in Africa, exceptional cases like Tanzania and Sierra Leone were at the other end of the spectrum from countries that were strict with lockdown. According to Haider *et al.*, (2020), South Africa and Uganda were stricter in the implementation of the lockdown, with similar progression in other countries. While Mbow *et al.*, (2020) opined that the swift response might have resulted in reduced imported cases and intra-country transmission, Villiers *et al.*, (2020), on the other hand, considered this swiftness to be inconsequential since infection continued to spike regardless of the initial lockdown.

Also, despite the low prevalence of COVID-19 recorded across the continent, the lingering impact of the pandemic on the socioeconomic infrastructure of countries in the continent is grave. And to a large extent, this can be attributed to the disposition of governments in the implementation of lockdown measures (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020). Arguably, the economy of Africa thrives and is largely sustained through informality. According to the International Labour Organisation, the informal economy has an estimated employment size of 89.2% of total employment in Sub-Saharan Africa alone (Balde *et al.*, 2020).

By implication, a total lockdown would collapse the sector and ultimately, the overall econ-

omy of the continent. Concomitantly, in Africa thus far, the rippling effect of the strict lockdown measures had ranged from massive job and welfare loss to colossal hunger and food insecurity, inflation, a sharp decline in tourism and trade and notably, the rise of conflict and violence (FAO, 2020; Balde *et al.*, 2020; Haider *et al.*, 2020; Lakemann *et al.*, 2020).

When examining the different containment measures adopted by African countries, it is arguable that the underlying sentiment is to prioritise human life, albeit with a marked economic trade-off (Villiers *et al.*, 2020). While lockdown measures may have aided the containment of the virus, the uncertainty around the epidemic remains unclear. And it is worth noting that epidemics like COVID-19 is not uncommon to what Africa has experienced in less than a decade, most prominently, the Ebola outbreak around 2014-2015 (Ali Mohamed *et al.*, 2021), and Lassa fever amidst other peculiar diseases like Malaria that have been ravaging the continent for decades (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). But the sharp convalescence and containment of the deadly Ebola outbreak in Africa without shutting down the entire economy provides enough evidence and blueprint on how Africa could have managed the lockdown during COVID-19 pandemic.

Ditto, it is upon this background that this study seeks to critique the COVID-19 lockdown in African countries, drawing on the existing literature in order to contribute to the unending debate of whether African governments should have prioritised health at the expense of the economy or not.

2 COVID-19 Pandemic and the Globalisation Discourse

Prior to this time, the fact that climate change impact has spared no country in the world corroborates the universality of space in global discourse. Although there are contentions on who shares the blame or responsibility, with the emergence of the COVID-19 pandemic, it becomes clear beyond doubt how countries and continents around the world

have shaped their realities within a shared global environment. The inequality parallel collapses when it comes to the consequences of climate change and pandemics like COVID-19.

From Wuhan city in China, the epicentre of COVID-19, the coronavirus completed the global spread in just 3 months. By April 2020, the novel coronavirus had reached all seven continents and affected about 213 countries and territories (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). Countries with the highest cases and casualties include the United States of America, Spain, Italy, Germany, France, the United Kingdom, China, Iran, Turkey, Belgium, the Russian Federation, Canada, Brazil and most recently South Africa and India. As of 6th August 2021, countries like the United States of America with an estimated 35 million confirmed cases and 609,613 mortalities, India with an estimated 31.8 million confirmed cases and 426,290 deaths and Brazil with approximately 20 million confirmed cases and 558,432 deaths, suffered severely from COVID-19 pandemic compared to the country where the virus originated from, China with 121, 175 confirmed cases and 5, 639 deaths (WHO, 2021b).

In Africa, the wave of the virus started on the 14th of February when the continent recorded its first case in Egypt. Thirteen days later, Nigeria, the most populous country on the continent, confirmed its first case- an Italian patient who flew to the country from Italy on the 25th of February 2020. Exactly 2 months after, 18th April 2020, the Africa Centre for Disease Control, reported 19,895 confirmed cases and 1,017 deaths from 52 out of 54 countries (with the exception of Lesotho and Comoros) on the continent (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). To further reinforce the globalisation argument, it is worth noting that most of the COVID-19 cases identified in Africa were imported from Europe and the United States rather than China where the coronavirus was first discovered.

Commendably, global efforts were jointly unleashed in ameliorating the dire consequences of the pandemic, particularly on less-developed economies. For instance, in Africa, Lake-

mann *et al.*, (2020) reported the suspension of debt service payments by G20, the \$214 million granted by IMF in debt relief, a further \$19 billion in emergency financing and additional regular financing to African governments estimated to be \$6 billion. Also, the World Bank in April 2020 announced its 15-month plan of spending \$55 billion in countering COVID-19 in Africa. Similarly, the private sector support committed about \$2 billion through the International Finance Corporation, with about \$422 million reported to have gone to Africa as well as the United States proposed COVID-19 response projects worth \$500 million. The Commissioner for International Partnerships, Jutta Urpilainen, announced the European Commission's €15.6 billion planned support for Africa (DW, 2020). Finally, the concerted effort of developed economies in making COVID-19 vaccines available to all and sundry further strengthens the globalisation discourse.

3 COVID-19 in Africa: Low Spread and Strict Lockdowns

At the prime of the pandemic, there were widespread speculations around the preparedness of Africa in combating the ravaging plague of COVID-19, as well as the extent of vulnerability of the African continent to the dire impact on health and livelihood. On one hand, the immunocompromised African population to the prevalence of Malaria, HIV, Hepatitis B and C, Respiratory diseases, among others, could reinforce the vulnerability argument (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). On the other end, several health and socioeconomic concerns were raised, such as the state of the healthcare system and infrastructure, population crowding, and poverty, amongst others (Mbow *et al.*, 2020).

Regarding the level of preparedness of Africa in combating coronavirus, factors such as shortage of fund for health sectors, lack of personal protective equipment (PPE) for health-care workers, limited testing capacity, paucity of skilled personnel required for diagnostics and intensive care units (ICU), further expose the susceptibility of the continent (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). Surprisingly, 18 months after the WHO declared COVID-19 as a global

pandemic, the incidence outlook is still relatively low compared to other continents of the world despite the various postulations. Myriad justifications of this have ranged from low testing and under-detection to under-reportage of cases (Haider *et al.*, 2020; Lakemann *et al.*, 2020).

However, looking at the figures, as of 6th August 2021, apart from Morocco, Tunisia, Egypt—which recorded over 10,000 deaths already, and South Africa—having the highest mortality of 73,415, about 61.2% of the total mortalities in Africa, all other countries had low mortality rate from COVID-19 (WHO, 2021b). To express optimism, Mbow *et al.*, (2020) explained that the majority of COVID-19-associated deaths can be traced to older people, whilst the relatively young African population has a median age of 20 compared to the United States, with 38.6 and 43.7 in Europe.

To cushion the proliferation of this deadly coronavirus and its effect on health and livelihood, the universal response was to introduce mass restrictions, widely referred to as a lockdown. This lockdown, as Haider *et al.*, (2020) and Villiers *et al.*, (2020) would argue, failed in clearly describing the scale, stringency, timeline, conditionality, as well as a definitive scope to which the measures should be applied. Given its universal relevance and acceptability, governments of African countries will not take chances in slamming lockdown as an aggressive response to the raging pandemic. Like Mbow *et al.*, (2020) would offer some insights, travel restrictions, school closures and curfews were implemented early in Africa, even in countries that had not confirmed any coronavirus cases.

According to the stringency index from OurWorldinData, as at 14th of February 2020, when the first COVID-19 case was confirmed in Africa, countries like Gabon, Guinea, Nigeria, Botswana and Uganda already introduced a lockdown, though not strict. The African continent, with an estimated 1.2 billion population, surpassed the one-million mark of confirmed cases in August 2020 (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020). Yet, extrapolated data from OurWorldinData revealed that, as of 19th April 2020, most African countries have

COVID-19: Stringency Index

This is a composite measure based on nine response indicators including school closures, workplace closures, and travel bans, rescaled to a value from 0 to 100 (100 = strictest). If policies vary at the subnational level, the index is shown as the response level of the strictest sub-region.

Our World
in Data

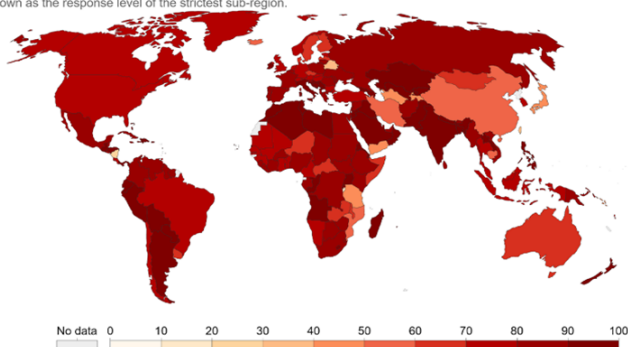


Figure A: Overall Stringency Index as at April 19, 2020

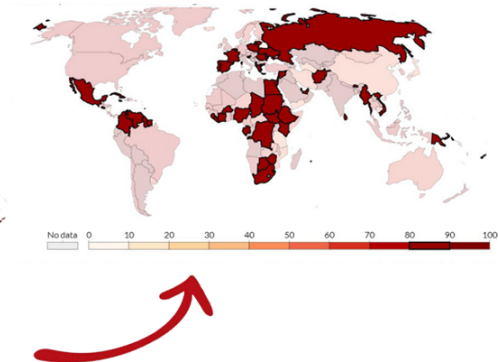


Figure B: Extracted Stringency Index of 80-90 as at April 19, 2020

Figure 1: Figure 1: Stringency Index by Hale et al. (2021)

implemented strict lockdowns, with the exceptions of Burundi and Tanzania with partial lockdowns, and Equatorial Guinea, Guinea-Bissau and Western Sahara, having no record. Explicitly, countries on the 80-90 stringency index include Egypt, Chad Republic, Sudan, South Sudan, Ethiopia, Nigeria, Kenya, Burkina Faso, Gabon, Côte d'Ivoire, Democratic Republic of Congo, Zimbabwe, Botswana, South Africa, Sierra Leone, and Liberia.

By the nine metrics used in computing this index, it implies that these countries implemented school and workplace closures, cancellation of public events, restrictions on public gatherings, closures of public transport, stay-at-home requirements, public information campaigns, restrictions on internal movements and international travel control (Skinner and Watson, 2021). Not until May 2020 onward did countries start reviewing their restrictive measures, with all international flights already suspended, and curfews mounted everywhere—not even sparing the rural communities. However, effective from September upwards, school closure was reviewed, and commercial flights resumed in Nigeria, Ghana, Rwanda, Kenya, then gradually, Ethiopia, South Africa, Madagascar, and others.

4 COVID-19 and the Informal Sector in Africa: The price for universal copying and mass pasting.

Arguably, the livelihood and economic consequences currently faced by most African countries cannot be severed from the stringent mitigation measures adopted by African governments in response to the pandemic. Majorly, sources of livelihood vis-à-vis economies in Africa thrive largely along the informal sector—playing a critical role particularly in employment and agri-food systems, which according to the International Labour Organisation, potentially constitute 60% of the entire labour force in the continent (Skinner and Watson, 2021). Since COVID-19 emerged, coupled with the complementary lockdown measures, the informal sector has suffered greatly.

Globally, ILO (2020) estimates revealed that 1.6 billion informal workers were severely impacted by the pandemic, resulting in about a 60% reduction in earnings. Taking stock in African countries, a study of 340 informal entrepreneurs in Kampala revealed total shut-downs and sharp depletion of profit to zero¹; despite low spread and mortality in Burkina Faso, Mali and Senegal. A study by Balde *et al.*, (2020) revealed how stringent lockdown measures made 25% of workers lose their jobs in all the countries, while 55% of the workers experienced a drastic reduction in earnings as at the end of April 2020.

Furthermore, the Agri-food system offers a comprehensive argument to the implications of prolonged and strict lockdown measures on the livelihoods of the majority of the African populace. From findings, a large number of people in Africa live below the poverty line, thrive on informality and are vulnerable to hunger and food insecurity (Ali Mohamed *et al.*, 2021). According to FAO (2020), in sub-Saharan Africa, 66 million people suffer from

¹See Hartwig, Renate, and Tabea Lakemann (2020), When the Going Gets Tough: Effects of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Informal Entrepreneurs in Uganda, Study within the Research Project “Performance and Dynamics of Micro and Small Enterprises in Developing Countries”, www.giga-hamburg.de/sites/default/files/md_pdf/2008_Corona_spotlight_Uganda.pdf.

acute food insecurity, let alone the 235 million hungry people struggling for daily bread in 2019 alone. Not just that, because of the disruptions in both the supply and the value chain of food, prices of food commodities skyrocketed. From the same source, 19 out of 30 countries observed recorded an increase in onions in August 2020; Zambia (onions and oranges), Mozambique (lettuce) and Djibouti (chicken meat) experienced the largest price increase. In Benin, Cabo Verde, Ghana, Mali, Niger, Senegal and Togo, cereal prices were up the ceiling by 40% in June 2020.

At the moment, Africa spends around \$35 billion on food importation, which constitutes about 85% of its consumption (Ali Mohamed *et al.*, 2021). By implication, prolonged or strict lockdown measures worsen the situation, implying that there is a higher probability of people dying of hunger than COVID-19. In response to the socioeconomic consequences of the COVID-19 pandemic, African governments set up social protection programmes, some of which include survival funds, cash transfers, palliatives and so on to cushion the effect of the pandemic on their citizens: the Nigerian government reeled out 2.3 trillion naira (\$6 billion) plan in its Economic Stability plan (Watch, 2021), Togolese government introduced Novissi for temporary cash transfer (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020), Senegalese government organised a stimulus package for businesses while Government of Mali set up a Private Sector Guarantee Fund for SMEs (Balde *et al.*, 2020).

Curiously, the effectiveness of these programmes in the face of compromising real data becomes worrisome. From April to May 2020, the Nigerian Bureau of Statistics revealed that 2% households had received cash transfers, while just 12% had received food assistance. Previously, the figure from the World Bank in 2019 showed that 4% of the poorest 40% of households have access to any social safety net program in Nigeria (Watch, 2021). This says a lot when examining the coverage and impact of the interventions.

5 Lower Infection and Higher Impact: COVID-19 in Africa

The colossal damage the COVID-19 pandemic had on the African continent is dire and cannot be reduced to predictions and assumptions. Be as it may, with the precarity of the novel coronavirus, even well-meaning stakeholders who could have assessed the impact took the safety route to stay at home. Also, the discrepancies along the economic divide, large rural areas and heterogeneous systems are clear indications that the impact can be unquantifiable. However, economies were plummeting, hunger struck harder, income dropped drastically, insecurity heightened, poverty gulf widened, food insecurity deepened, and schools were closed for months amidst other losses (Ali Mohamed *et al.*, 2021; FAO, 2020; Lakemann *et al.*, 2020; Lone and Ahmad, 2020).

At the macroeconomic level, negative gross domestic product (GDP) was projected for countries like Angola (-1.2%), Nigeria (-1.6%), Zimbabwe (-5%), Ethiopia (-5.6%), and Equatorial Guinea (-5.8%) (FAO, 2020). In sub-Saharan Africa alone, economic growth was projected to decimate to between -2% and -5% (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). As a result of the pandemic, the global demand dropped drastically. According to the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa, African exports declined by 5% in February, 16% in March and 32% in April 2020 compared to 2019. Similarly, imports declined by 1%, 7%, and 25% in February, March, and April, respectively (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020).

With border closures, oil-producing countries like Nigeria, Angola, Algeria and others experienced a shortfall; countries like South Africa, Ethiopia, Kenya, and Tanzania, whose economy is driven by Tourism suffered a huge economic blow. Equally, Foreign Direct Investment decimated greatly as projects and programmes could not progress with Covid-19 (Lone and Ahmad, 2020). Despite all these pandemic-induced retrogression, food importation remained resilient, increasing by more than 10% in April in many African countries. Furthermore, remittances significantly helped in cushioning the economic shock that

COVID-19 caused in Africa. It is surprising to see countries like Nigeria, Ghana, Kenya and Uganda made a significant economic recovery in the third quarter of 2020 (Lakemann *et al.*, 2020). Apparently, lockdown measures have been reviewed in most countries by this time.

6 Conclusion

With scepticism and uncertainties accompanying the emergence of the COVID-19 pandemic, lockdown is inevitable. However, the scale, scope and stringency should be within the context of prevailing socio-economic conditions, infection rate, social protection system, amongst others. In Africa's case, being proactive early with the international travel ban while the spread is low was a step in the right direction if there is no compromise with the ban. No doubt, this will restrain imported cases and reduce intercountry spread; however, mounting stringent restrictions at the detriment of the livelihood of the populace was catastrophic.

Apparently, the informal economy constitutes the largest provider of income, employment, and a source of livelihood, as well as the agri-food system in most countries in Africa. Yet, police and military were suppressing people to comply with the stay-at-home order even in the most remote part of the country (Skinner and Watson, 2021). All these were not without a consequence, massive job and income loss, hunger, heightened insecurity and crime rate, emotional and psychological trauma, etc.

Markedly, Africa has experienced virulent cases like coronavirus before, such as the Ebola virus and Lassa fever. Hence, the African government should have taken a cue from the containment measures employed, which exempt total lockdown of the economy. In the midst of this, countries like Tanzania and Sierra Leone were strategic in selectively employing lockdown measures. Of course, the opposing argument is the credibility of the case

and mortality reportage; however, countries that were badly hit by coronavirus need not do much publicity before the global community gets to know the extent of their COVID-19 fatality.

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